Music in "The Hunger Games": A Divided Approach for a Divided Society

Introduction

Music in film enhances the impact of a film, as it shapes the audience's perception and engagement with the film using the emotional and cultural associations we have with elements of music. In the film adaptation of Suzanne Collins' The Hunger Games, composed by James Newton Howard, the score utilizes two very different approaches to the music of the extravagant yet oppressive Capitol, and the austere and struggling District 12. The music accompanying District 12 mirrors the harsh conditions and struggles of life in 12, using acoustic instrumentation and isolated vocals. In contrast, the brass dominated orchestral themes that accompany the Capitol evoke the grandiosity and excess of the Capitol while expressing its power over the districts. In this paper, I will explore the distinct musical approaches to scoring District 12 and the Capitol, and I will argue the contrasting musical approaches between District 12 and the Capitol underscore the socio-cultural disparities in the divided society of Panem.

Review

In researching for this assignment, I found several reviews and articles specifically noting the restrained approach to the score and the use of folk influence. Fitzgerald and Hayward's article on the role of song in The Hunger Games, highlights the contrasting sounds of the districts and the capitol, and the use of folk influence to establish a cultural link for the audience. Specifically in the early scenes of District 12, they describe the "folk-style Aeolian melodic idea" sung by two voices. The music here creates a complex ambiance through its sustained tones and the diegetic environmental sounds. They argue that the traditional Appalachian musical motif connects Katniss with a pre-dystopian past that allows her to confront the dystopian

modernity of the Capitol. Through the lack of overly futuristic music in the film, the score offers a cultural and grounded meaning to the narrative that is lacking in science fiction films.

Both reviews of the film's score on Movie Wave and Filmtracks discuss Howard's restrained approach to scoring the film. Southall's review praises the folk approach to scoring Katniss and District 12, and the earthy quality of the score. He notes that there are only two full orchestral moments outside of the Capitol theme, "Horn of Plenty", in the moments of Rue's death and in the chase with the mutant dogs. However, he notes that much of the score composed by Howard went unused, instead his score was used very sparingly throughout the film. Filmtracks similarly note this incomplete usage of the score.The Filmtracks review also notes that the film lacks leitmotifs or themes for the characters, and instead the instrumentation and musical style choices mark the characters and themes in the film.

Synopsis

The Hunger Games is set in the dystopian nation of Panem, divided into twelve districts and the Capitol. As a means of punishment and control, each year the Capitol requires the districts to send two children to compete in the Hunger Games, a televised fight to the death. The story follows Katniss Everdeen, a skilled hunter from District 12, after she volunteers to take her sister's place as a tribute. She and the other District 12 tribute, Peeta Mellark, are sent to the Capitol to train and make public appearances, where they witness the extravagance and excess of the Capitol. During the games, Katniss uses her archery and survival skills from hunting to survive the deadly arena. However, she not only faces threats from the other tributes but from the Capitol itself, as the game-makers manipulate the arena for the Capitol's entertainment and political control over the districts. After days of bloodshed, Katniss and Peeta defy the Capitol by

refusing to kill each other, opting instead to take their own lives and leave the games without a victor. The game-makers, rather than have no victor, stop them and declare that they both have won the 74th Hunger Games.

Findings

In the first scene we see with Katniss, we hear a haunting monophonic vocal melody, accompanying shots of the hardships and struggles in District 12. As Katniss heads to the district border, she passes fatigued coal miners, a starving man, children covered in dirt, and other melancholic sights of life in Twelve. The music here is slow, taking large pauses in between phrases and lingering on each note, mirroring the languid District 12. Low strings play quietly under the vocals as Katniss crosses the border and enters the forest. She grabs her bow and arrows from their hiding places in the trees and a single pizzicato note marks the beginning of her hunt. A harmony line joins the vocal melody, taking more time in between phrases, leaving the low strings and occasional pizzicato note to ring out.

We hear this music again in the Hob, District 12's Black Market, where we see more of the impoverished and desolate life in Twelve. At the Hob, Katniss exchanges the results of her hunt, and notices a golden pin of a mockingjay on an arrow. As she picks up the pin, we hear a high siren, emerging almost as an alarm as the vocals stop, leaving just the tense underlying strings. The vocals resume once again as we see more shots of Twelve, as mothers soberly dress their children for the reaping, and peacekeepers patrol the district. The music fades out as Katniss prepares herself for the reaping.

The music of District 12 combines a variety of musical elements to evoke a somber mood. Through its minor key and sparse texture, the music creates an immediately eerie feel, emphasizing the hardships faced by the residents in Twelve. The choice of instrumentation is especially of note in the musical approach to District 12, as the use of solo vocals and minimal string accompaniment establishes a grounded and rustic feel, and refletincing the simplicity and struggle within the district. The restrained approach to the instrumentation also allows the narrative to resonate more deeply with the audience. By incorporating elements of folk music, the film alludes to District 12's cultural roots in the Appalachian region, reinforcing the audience's understanding. The folksy feel of the music not only serves as a cultural tool, but also echoes the natural images of the forest outside of Twelve. This connection between the music and the environment not only enhances the atmosphere of the scene, as it emphasizes Katniss' close relationship to the woods, giving the audience further insight into her character.

The deliberate space in between musical phrases and use of silence highlights the subtle approach to scoring District 12. Moments of silence or sustained low strings create moments of contemplation, allowing the audience to take in the somber imagery. Meanwhile the simplicity and slow pace of the melody direct attention to the bleak reality for Katniss and her district. Each note of the melody is deliberate and unhurried, as if it were carrying the weight of the struggles in Twelve, mirroring the simplistic yet profound imagery of those struggles. Using a single pitch against the thin texture, in moments like when Katniss picks up the pin, produces a weightier effect, drawing attention to the importance of the mockingjay symbol. The intentional adherence to a thin musical texture avoids obscuring the significance of a single pitch paired with a visual symbol, ensuring that the audience resonates with the symbolism. The thin texture reflects the significance of small actions and items in the seemingly hopeless lives of the residents in

Twelve. By remaining simplistic and hollow, the score highlights the importance of small details, portraying the importance of small acts in the face of adversity.

We first hear the music of the Capitol in a film shown to the citizens of District 12 before the reaping, explaining the significance of the Hunger Games. However, the music played in the film is distorted through the speakers and buried under narration. As Peeta and Katniss witness the Capitol, we also experience its music for the first time. Emerging out of atmospheric horns, loud dissonant horns and driving percussion play over images of the Capitol's grand buildings and eccentric citizens.

Pieces of the Capitol's theme begin to layer as the tributes prepare to mount the chariots for the grand Tribute Parade. A soft pulsing snare and swelling horns build the excitement and anticipation, and more horns play phrases of the Capitol theme, however, all with incomplete cadences. As the television hosts narrate the excitement of the event, we see the Capitol citizens overjoyed and bursting with anticipation and President Snow sternly watching over the scene. The music stops during the game-makers' countdown for the parade and resumes as the chariots take off. We hear the opening to the Capitol theme properly now; the melody sung by a choir, over horns and marching percussion. The music suspends once again when audience and television hosts react to the District 12 tributes. We hear a large build up and then the film cuts to Katniss and Peeta and we see their flaming costumes, accompanied by a loud and full version of the Capitol theme.

Through Katniss and Peeta's perspective, we witness life in the Capitol for the first time. Departing from the previously introduced thematic elements, the characteristic horns and percussion of the Capitol take on a dissonant and unsettling sound. The score contextualizes the

eccentric look of the Capitol citizens and the futuristic landscape of the Capitol through Peeta and Katniss's perspective by evoking their feelings of discomfort through musical dissonance. The dissonant melodies amplify the character's feelings of discomfort and alienation when faced with the extravagance of life in the Capitol. The music dissonance pairs with the unsettling visuals of the Capitol, deepening our understanding of the stark divide between the districts and the Capitol's lifestyles.

During the Tribute Parade, we get a much better understanding of the Capitol's theme, "Horn of Plenty", in its full glory. By utilizing marching percussion, the theme instills a subtle warlike vibe that further emphasizes the Capitol's dominance and cruelty towards the districts. The brass sections generate an atmosphere of celebration and grandiosity, emphasizing the Capitol's extravagance and excessiveness. The theme's choral vocals highlight the Capitol's dominance over the districts through their collective strength. Compared to other music in the film, the Capitol theme is significantly louder and fuller, illustrating the government's powerful and oppressive nature towards the districts.

Conclusion/discussion

The juxtaposition of the music in the film highlights the socio-cultural commentary of the film, pairing the stripped down, somber music of Twelve with the blaring and dominating theme of the Capitol. Howard very carefully composed the contrasting themes to emphasize one of the core elements of the story, the disparity between the districts and the Capitol. The choice of the grounded and restrained folk approach to scoring District 12 provides a sense of simplicity and struggle. The folk-inspired score not only creates an emotional response to the images of Twelve, but also a cultural association for the audience, providing the audience with the context for the

district's Appalachian roots. On the other hand the blaring anthem of the Capitol emerges as a stark contrast to the music of Twelve. The theme's brass and percussion illustrate the Capitol's dominance over the districts and its militaristic strength through its full texture. The Capitol's orchestral anthem becomes a symbol of its control over the districts, overpowering the simplistic vocals and strings of the districts, underscoring the political commentary central to The Hunger Games.

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